

Supplementary Material

S0. Comparative analysis of closely related influencer-marketing studies

Table S0. Comparative analysis of closely related influencer-marketing studies

Ref.	Why selected
(Sokolova & Kefi, 2020)	Core credibility + parasocial interaction + purchase intention paper
(Lou & Kim, 2019)	Influencer content, credibility, parasocial relationship, purchase intentions
(Reinikainen et al., 2020)	Parasocial relationships and credibility in influencer marketing
(Aw & Chuah, 2021)	Parasocial relationships and influencer characteristics
(Ashraf et al., 2023)	Source credibility dimensions → parasocial relationships → purchase intention
(Bi & Zhang, 2023)	Parasocial relationship, influencer credibility, and purchase intention
(Du et al., 2023)	Parasocial relationship and influencer–product congruence
(Dangi, 2023)	Influencer credibility and congruence
(Gubalane & Ha, 2023)	Product–influencer fit as mediator
(Alcántara-Pilar et al., 2024)	TikTok influencer credibility with SEM and neural network validation
(Hawkins & Saleem, 2024)	Influencer–brand fit and purchase intention
(Che et al., 2025)	Functional/image brand–influencer fit
(Kim et al., 2025)	Influencer–product fit, skepticism, and purchase intention
(Zaki et al., 2025)	ML-based influencer credibility and purchase intent
(Azad et al., 2023)	Behavioural theory + ML prediction of social-media purchase behaviour

Table S0.1. Comparative analysis of closely related influencer-marketing studies

Study	Context/plat form	Core variables	Method	Key finding	Main limitation/gap	Relevance to present study
(Lou & Kim, 2019)	Adolescents and social media influencers	Influencer content, credibility, parasocial relationship, materialism, and purchase intention	Survey and SEM	Influence r credibility and content value influence parasocial relationships and purchase intentions	Focused on adolescents; limited product–influencer fit and ML validation.	Supports credibility–PSI–purchase pathway.
(Sokolova & Kefi, 2020)	Instagram and YouTube influencers	Credibility, parasocial interaction, and purchase intention	SEM	Credibility and parasocial interaction influence purchase intention.	Limited predictive modeling and fit-based boundary testing.	Provides core theoretical foundation.
(Reinikainen et al., 2020)	Influencer marketing	Parasocial relationship, credibility, and audience comments	Experimental/survey design	Parasocial relationships strengthen	Does not integrate product-fit and ML prediction.	Supports relational mechanism.

				credibility-related influence outcomes.		
(Aw & Chuah, 2021)	Social media influencers	Influencer characteristics, parasocial relationship, and purchase intention	PLS-SEM	Influencers attempt to influence parasocial relationships and downstream purchase responses.	Limited direct comparison between SEM and ML prediction.	Supports PSI as an explanatory mechanism.
(Ashraf et al., 2023)	Technology-oriented SMIs	Attractiveness, expertise, trustworthiness, similarity, PSR, purchase intention	SEM	Source credibility dimensions indirectly influence purchase intention through parasocial relationships.	Product–influencer fit not central; no ML validation.	Strong support for mediation logic.
(Bi & Zhang, 2023)	YouTube influencers	Parasocial relationships, influencer credibility, self-esteem, product attitude, purchase intention	Survey and PROCESS	Influencer credibility and product attitude mediate the links between PSR and purchase intention.	Different causal ordering from the present model.	Helps position alternative mediation logic.
(Du et al., 2023)	Online video product placement	Parasocial relationship, influencer–product congruence, reactance, purchase intention	Experiment and PROCESS	PSR and influencer–product congruence improve attitude and purchase intention by reducing reactance.	Experimental design; not focused on credibility dimensions.	Supports product-fit relevance.

(Dangi, 2023)	Instagram influencer marketing	Influencer credibility, influencer–brand congruence, brand attitude, eWOM	SEM	Credibility and congruence influence brand attitude and eWOM.	Purchase intention is not the only outcome; no PSI mediation.	Supports congruence and credibility logic.
(Gubalan e & Ha, 2023)	Social media influencers	Credibility, product evaluation, product attitude, product–influencer fit, purchase intention	SEM	Product–influencer fit mediates selected credibility effects.	Fit is treated mainly as a mediator, not a direct/moderating factor.	Supports testing fit role more explicitly.
(Alcántara-Pilar et al., 2024)	TikTok	Influencer credibility, trust, loyalty, purchase intention	SEM and neural network	SEM identified predictors and neural network validated them.	Less emphasis on PSI and product–influencer fit.	Supports SEM–ML design.
(Hawkins & Saleem, 2024)	Influencer advertising	Influencer–brand fit, sponsorship, trust, purchase intention	Experiment and PROCESS	Influencer trust mediates the relationship between influencer–brand fit and purchase intention.	Focused on sponsorship and fit, not PSI mechanism.	Supports the direct role of fit.
(Che et al., 2025)	Brand–influencer fit	Functional fit, image fit, brand attitude	Multi-study design	Functional and image fit positively influence brand attitude.	The outcome is brand attitude rather than purchase intention.	Supports fit as a multidimensional cue.
(Kim et al., 2025)	Influencer marketing skepticism	Influencer–product fit, content style, ad skepticism, purchase intention	Survey/experimental analysis	Fit and content style shape skepticism and purchase intention.	Focuses on skepticism rather than parasocial interaction.	Supports fit as a boundary/evaluative cue.
(Zaki et al., 2025)	Social media marketing	Influencer credibility, brand admiration, purchase intent	Machine learning	ML helps analyze credibility effects on purchase intent.	Less theory-driven mediation/moderation testing.	Supports predictive analytics contribution.

(Azad et al., 2023)	Social media purchase behavior	TPB variables, purchase behavior, ML models	ML with behavioral theory	ML improves predictions of social media purchase behavior.	Not influencer-specific.	Supports behavioral theory + ML logic.
Present study	Short-video/social-commerce influencer context	Trustworthiness, expertise, attractiveness, parasocial interaction, product–influencer fit, purchase intention	SEM-style path modeling, mediation, moderation, ML prediction	Test credibility → PSI → purchase intention, direct and interactive fit effects, and ML predictive robustness.	Cross-sectional and self-reported intention-based design.	Integrates credibility, PSI, fit, and SEM–ML validation into a single model.

S1. Questionnaire, Coding Scheme, and Data Preparation

S1.1 Survey design and measurement scale

The study used a structured questionnaire to measure influencer credibility, parasocial interaction, product–influencer fit, and purchase intention. The questionnaire included measures of demographics, social media usage, product category, and multi-item constructs. All construct items were measured using a seven-point Likert scale:

- 1 = Strongly disagree
- 2 = Disagree
- 3 = Slightly disagree
- 4 = Neutral
- 5 = Slightly agree
- 6 = Agree
- 7 = Strongly agree

Table S1. Respondent screening and variable coding.

Variable/process	Description	Coding/criterion
Respondent inclusion	Young social-media users are familiar with influencer product recommendations	Retained if eligible
Missing values	Item-level missing responses	Screened before analysis
Duplicate IDs	Duplicate respondent identification numbers	Removed if present
Likert response range	Valid response range for construct items	1–7
Gender	Gender of respondent	1 = Male, 2 = Female
Age	Respondent age	18–26 years
City_Tier	City classification	1 = Tier-1, 2 = New Tier-1
Platform	Most-used platform	1 = Douyin, 2 = Kuaishou, 3 = Xiaohongshu
Product_Category	Preferred product category	1 = Beauty, 2 = Apparel, 3 = Food
Daily_Usage_Minutes	Daily social-media usage	Minutes per day

Table S2. Questionnaire items and construct mapping.

Construct	Item code	Item wording
Trustworthiness	TR1	The influencer is honest.

Trustworthiness	TR2	The influencer is dependable.
Trustworthiness	TR3	The influencer is trustworthy.
Trustworthiness	TR4	The influencer's recommendations are believable.
Expertise	EX1	The influencer is knowledgeable.
Expertise	EX2	The influencer is experienced.
Expertise	EX3	The influencer is an expert in the promoted product/category.
Expertise	EX4	The information provided by the influencer is useful.
Attractiveness	AT1	The influencer is attractive.
Attractiveness	AT2	The influencer is stylish.
Attractiveness	AT3	The influencer has an appealing personality.
Attractiveness	AT4	The influencer is charismatic.
Parasocial Interaction	PSI1	I feel connected to the influencer.
Parasocial Interaction	PSI2	I miss the influencer when they are inactive.
Parasocial Interaction	PSI3	The influencer feels like a friend.
Parasocial Interaction	PSI4	I enjoy watching the influencer regularly.
Parasocial Interaction	PSI5	I feel emotionally attached to the influencer.
Product–Influencer Fit	PIF1	The influencer matches the product well.
Product–Influencer Fit	PIF2	The influencer is suitable for the product.
Product–Influencer Fit	PIF3	The endorsement feels natural.
Product–Influencer Fit	PIF4	The influencer's image fits the brand/product.
Purchase Intention	PI1	I am likely to buy products recommended by the influencer.
Purchase Intention	PI2	I would consider purchasing products recommended by the influencer.
Purchase Intention	PI3	I intend to try endorsed products.
Purchase Intention	PI4	I may purchase endorsed products in the future.

Table S3. Construct score calculation.

Construct	Formula
Trustworthiness	Mean of TR1, TR2, TR3, TR4
Expertise	Mean of EX1, EX2, EX3, EX4
Attractiveness	Mean of AT1, AT2, AT3, AT4
Parasocial Interaction	Mean of PSI1, PSI2, PSI3, PSI4, PSI5
Product–Influencer Fit	Mean of PIF1, PIF2, PIF3, PIF4
Purchase Intention	Mean of PI1, PI2, PI3, PI4

S1.2 Data preprocessing procedure

The following preprocessing steps were applied before analysis:

- Data were imported into Python using pandas.
- Variable names were checked and standardized.
- Missing values were screened.
- Duplicate respondent IDs were checked.
- Likert-scale items were checked for out-of-range values.
- Construct scores were calculated using item-level averages.
- The interaction term between parasocial interaction and product–influencer fit was computed.

- The cleaned dataset was used for descriptive analysis, reliability testing, structural modeling, mediation analysis, moderation testing, and machine-learning prediction.

S1.3 Supplementary result files linked to methodology

The following supplementary outputs support the methodology section:

Supplementary item	Description
Table S4	Full descriptive statistics
Table S5	Full construct correlation matrix
Figure S1	Construct-level correlation heatmap
Table S6	Full reliability and validity diagnostics
Table S7	Complete structural path and regression outputs
Table S8	Mediation and moderation results
Table S9	Machine-learning model metrics and feature-importance results
Figure S2	Machine-learning model comparison and feature-importance plots

Supplementary Material S2. Detailed Results

Table S4. Full descriptive statistics.

Construct	n	Mean	SD	Min	25%	Median	75%	Max
Trustworthiness	1000	3.945	1.674	1.000	2.500	4.000	5.250	7.000
Expertise	1000	3.902	1.679	1.000	2.500	4.000	5.250	7.000
Attractiveness	1000	3.985	1.633	1.000	2.750	4.000	5.250	7.000
Parasocial Interaction	1000	3.906	2.048	1.000	2.000	3.800	5.800	7.000
Product–Influencer Fit	1000	3.896	1.734	1.000	2.500	4.000	5.250	7.000
Purchase Intention	1000	3.845	2.115	1.000	1.750	3.750	5.750	7.000

Table S5 presents the construct-level correlation matrix. All constructs show positive associations. The strongest correlation is observed between parasocial interaction and purchase intention, supporting the central role of parasocial interaction in explaining purchase intention driven by influencers. Product–influencer fit also shows a positive association with purchase intention, supporting its role as an important direct predictor in the structural model. The matrix is visualized in **Figure S1**.

Table S5. Construct-level correlation matrix.

Construct	TR	EX	AT	PSI	PIF	PI
TR	1.00	0.56	0.28	0.69	0.46	0.63
EX	0.56	1.00	0.25	0.69	0.41	0.60
AT	0.28	0.25	1.00	0.44	0.31	0.38
PSI	0.69	0.69	0.44	1.00	0.59	0.82
PIF	0.46	0.41	0.31	0.59	1.00	0.64
PI	0.63	0.60	0.38	0.82	0.64	1.00

Note. TR = Trustworthiness; EX = Expertise; AT = Attractiveness; PSI = Parasocial Interaction; PIF = Product–Influencer Fit; PI = Purchase Intention.

The construct-level correlation matrix is visualized in **Figure S1**. The heatmap shows positive associations among all major constructs, with the strongest relationship observed between parasocial interaction and purchase intention. Product–influencer fit also shows a positive association with purchase intention, supporting its role as an important predictor in the structural model.

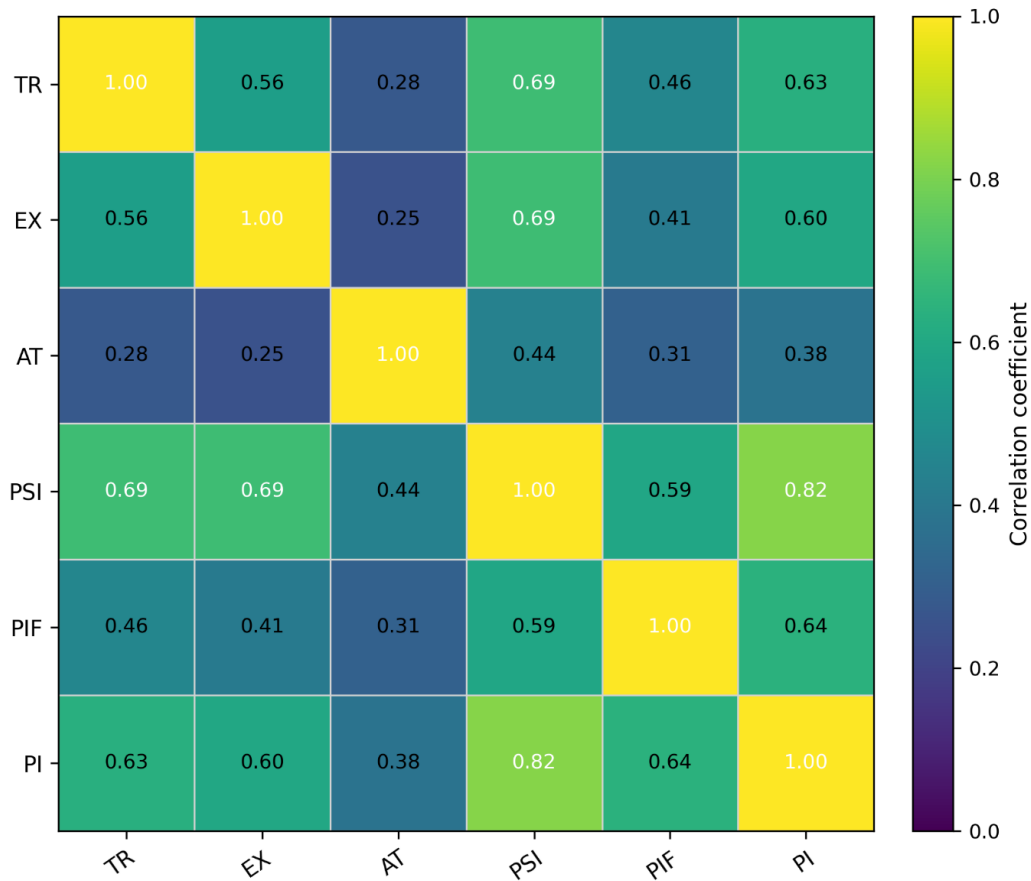


Figure S1. Main survey construct correlation heatmap.

Main Survey Construct Correlations

Table S6. Reliability and validity diagnostics.

Construct	Items	Cronbach's alpha	Composite reliability	AVE
Trustworthiness	4	0.872	0.912	0.722
Expertise	4	0.877	0.915	0.730
Attractiveness	4	0.866	0.908	0.713
Parasocial Interaction	5	0.948	0.960	0.828
Product–Influencer Fit	4	0.890	0.924	0.751
Purchase Intention	4	0.941	0.958	0.850

Table S7. Complete structural regression outputs.

Model	Dependent variable	Predictor	β	SE	t	p	R ²
Credibility → PSI	PSI	Trustworthiness	0.484	0.028	17.314	<0.001	0.657
Credibility → PSI	PSI	Expertise	0.502	0.028	18.182	<0.001	0.657
Credibility → PSI	PSI	Attractiveness	0.282	0.024	11.515	<0.001	0.657
Purchase intention model	PI	Trustworthiness	0.102	0.030	3.405	<0.001	0.720
Purchase intention model	PI	Expertise	0.065	0.030	2.178	0.030	0.720
Purchase intention model	PI	Attractiveness	0.011	0.024	0.448	0.655	0.720
Purchase intention model	PI	Parasocial Interaction	0.613	0.031	19.502	<0.001	0.720
Purchase intention model	PI	Product–Influencer Fit	0.279	0.026	10.946	<0.001	0.720

Table S8. Mediation and moderation results.

Mediation through parasocial interaction

Pathway	Indirect effect	95% CI lower	95% CI upper	Interpretation
Trustworthiness → PSI → Purchase Intention	0.652	0.594	0.714	Significant mediation
Expertise → PSI → Purchase Intention	0.678	0.620	0.729	Significant mediation
Attractiveness → PSI → Purchase Intention	0.466	0.405	0.513	Significant mediation

Moderation by product–influencer fit

Predictor	β	SE	t	p	Interpretation
Parasocial Interaction	1.446	0.044	32.662	<0.001	Significant main effect
Product–Influencer Fit	0.498	0.044	11.234	<0.001	Significant main effect
PSI × Product–Influencer Fit	0.042	0.039	1.090	0.276	Moderation not supported

Table S9. Machine-learning model performance

Model	RMSE	MAE	R ²	Cross-validated R ²
Linear Regression	1.025	0.787	0.762	0.718
Ridge Regression	1.025	0.787	0.762	0.718
SVR-RBF	1.081	0.793	0.735	0.702
Gradient Boosting	1.114	0.837	0.719	0.700
Random Forest	1.125	0.856	0.713	0.688
Extra Trees	1.131	0.851	0.710	0.681
Elastic Net	1.342	1.181	0.592	0.566
Lasso	1.522	1.347	0.474	0.453

Table S10 reports the full permutation-importance values across four machine-learning models. Across all models, parasocial interaction had the highest predictive importance, followed by product–influencer fit. Trustworthiness and expertise provided smaller but positive predictive contributions, whereas attractiveness showed the weakest contribution after parasocial interaction and product–influencer fit were included. These results are visualized in **Figure S3**.

Table S10. Full permutation-importance values for purchase-intention prediction.

Model	Predictor	Permutation importance R ²	Importance SD
Ridge	Trustworthiness	0.0157	0.0040
Ridge	Expertise	0.0065	0.0027
Ridge	Attractiveness	0.0006	0.0005
Ridge	Parasocial Interaction	0.6681	0.0375
Ridge	Product–Influencer Fit	0.0999	0.0069
Random Forest	Trustworthiness	0.0245	0.0077
Random Forest	Expertise	0.0242	0.0052
Random Forest	Attractiveness	-0.0030	0.0029
Random Forest	Parasocial Interaction	0.7126	0.0471
Random Forest	Product–Influencer Fit	0.0841	0.0092
Extra Trees	Trustworthiness	0.0197	0.0078
Extra Trees	Expertise	0.0070	0.0100
Extra Trees	Attractiveness	0.0008	0.0021
Extra Trees	Parasocial Interaction	0.7168	0.0418
Extra Trees	Product–Influencer Fit	0.1029	0.0127
Gradient Boosting	Trustworthiness	0.0108	0.0059
Gradient Boosting	Expertise	0.0375	0.0120
Gradient Boosting	Attractiveness	0.0137	0.0077
Gradient Boosting	Parasocial Interaction	0.7318	0.0407
Gradient Boosting	Product–Influencer Fit	0.1036	0.0167

Note. Permutation importance represents the reduction in model R^2 when a predictor is randomly permuted. Higher values indicate stronger predictive contribution. A small negative value indicates that permuting the predictor did not reduce predictive performance and may reflect a negligible contribution.

The machine-learning model comparison is shown in **Figure S2**. Linear and ridge regression achieved the highest test-set R^2 values, indicating that purchase intention was explained well by the theoretical predictors. SVR-RBF, gradient boosting, random forest, and extra trees also showed moderate-to-strong predictive performance, whereas elastic net and lasso performed comparatively weaker.

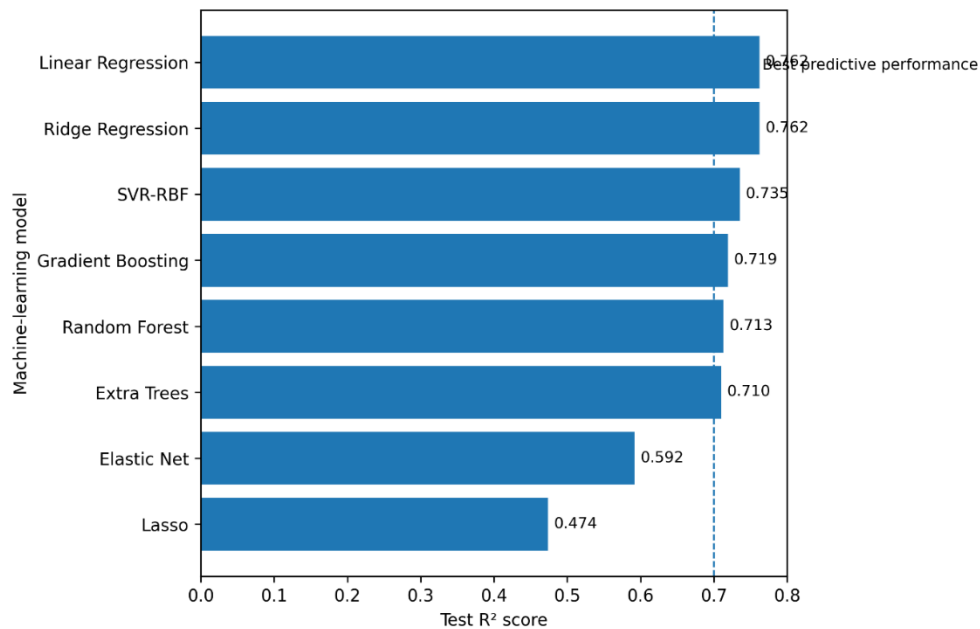


Figure S2. Machine-learning model comparison and feature-importance plots.

The feature-importance results are shown in **Figure S3**. Parasocial interaction emerged as the dominant predictor of purchase intention, followed by product–influencer fit. Trustworthiness and expertise provided additional, albeit comparatively smaller, predictive contributions, while attractiveness showed the lowest relative importance after relational and fit-based predictors were considered.

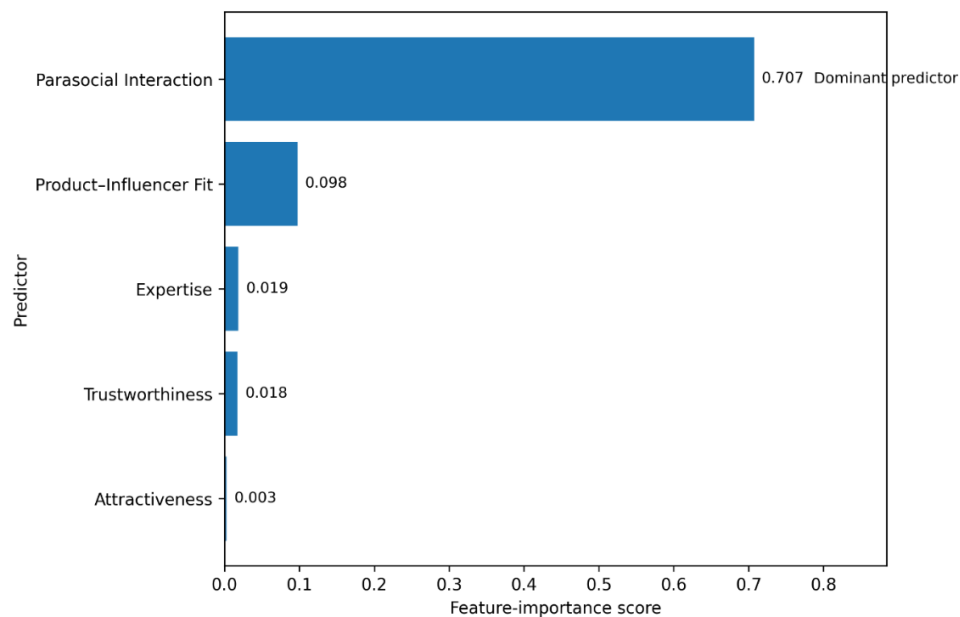


Figure S3. Feature-importance plot for purchase-intention prediction.

S3. External Robustness Validation

S3.1 External dataset and validation purpose

To conduct an external robustness validation, an independent influencer marketing data set was utilized to test the generalizability of the predictive component of the SEM-machine learning framework beyond the primary survey data set. The independent dataset provided responses regarding: (1) influencer credibility, (2) information quality, (3) entertainment value, and (4) purchase intention. Because the independent data set did not include the same full latent variable structure, item wording, or number of response options as the primary survey data set, the external validation was limited to testing the machine-learning aspect of the SEM-machine-learning framework.

The external validation served as an additional robustness check, not as an attempt to re-estimate the overall structural model, mediation paths, or moderating effects, but rather to determine whether theoretically similar credibility (influencer) and content-related predictor variables for Likert-scale purchase intention could be found in an independent dataset. Only individuals who indicated they followed social media influencers in the external dataset were included in the analysis, resulting in a final total of 76 usable responses for external validation.

Table S11. External dataset description and validation design.

Component	Description
External dataset type	Independent influencer-marketing survey dataset
Validation purpose	External robustness validation of the machine-learning component
Original analytical focus	Influencer credibility, information quality, entertainment value, and purchase intention
Filter applied	Respondents who reported following social media influencers
Final usable sample	76 respondents
Target variable	“I would purchase brands endorsed by influencers”
Target coding	Likert-scale purchase intention coded as a continuous score
Validation approach	Repeated 5-fold cross-validation with three repeats
SEM replication	Not performed because the external dataset used a non-identical construct and item structure
Interpretation	Supplementary robustness evidence, not direct replication

S3.2 Construct mapping and variable preparation

Variables that conceptually overlap were kept from the external dataset and combined into composite predictors. These included measures of influencer expertise, trustworthiness, attractiveness/likeability, argument quality, information credibility, and entertainment value. The selection was based on their relevance to credibility, content, and engagement factors that influence purchase intention driven by influencers. The main outcome variable was a Likert-scale item: “I would purchase brands endorsed by influencers,” treated as a continuous measure of purchase intention.

Table S12. Construct mapping for external validation.

External validation construct	Item/domain used for construct formation	Relevance to the present study
Expertise	Expert, experienced, qualified, skilled	Corresponds to the expertise dimension of influencer credibility
Trustworthiness	Dependable, honest, reliable	Corresponds to the trustworthiness dimension of influencer credibility
Attractiveness/likeability	Friendly, likable	Conceptually related to attractiveness and interpersonal appeal
Argument quality	Convincing and supported by strong arguments	Represents persuasive content quality
Information credibility	Believable and reliable information	Represents credibility of influencer-provided product information
Entertainment value	Exciting, delightful, thrilling, enjoyable	Represents content engagement and affective appeal

Purchase intention	“I would purchase brands endorsed by influencers.”	External target variable for Likert-scale purchase intention prediction
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S3.3 External validation modelling procedure

The external dataset was analyzed using supervised regression models because the purchase-intention target was coded as a continuous Likert-scale score. The following models were evaluated: Linear Regression, Ridge Regression, Support Vector Regression, Random Forest, and Gradient Boosting. Model performance was assessed using mean absolute error, root mean squared error, and coefficient of determination. Repeated 5-fold cross-validation with three repeats was used to reduce the instability associated with the relatively small external sample.

Table S13. External validation model performance using Likert-scale purchase intention as the target variable.

Model	MAE	RMSE	R²
Gradient Boosting	0.668	0.799	0.030
Random Forest	0.680	0.816	0.010
SVR	0.666	0.828	-0.045
Ridge Regression	0.800	0.954	-0.361
Linear Regression	0.817	0.977	-0.435

Note. MAE = mean absolute error; RMSE = root mean squared error; R² = coefficient of determination. Gradient Boosting was identified as the best-performing external validation model because it achieved the lowest RMSE and the highest R².

S3.4 Feature-importance results from the external validation model

Feature importance was extracted from the best-performing external validation model. The results showed that entertainment value was the strongest predictor of Likert-scale purchase intention, followed by trustworthiness, information credibility, argument quality, and expertise. This pattern indicates that content engagement and credibility-related variables retained predictive relevance in the independent dataset.

Table S14. Feature-importance ranking from the best-performing external validation model.

Rank	Predictor	Importance
1	Entertainment value	0.251
2	Trustworthiness	0.091
3	Information credibility	0.083
4	Argument quality	0.046
5	Expertise	0.035

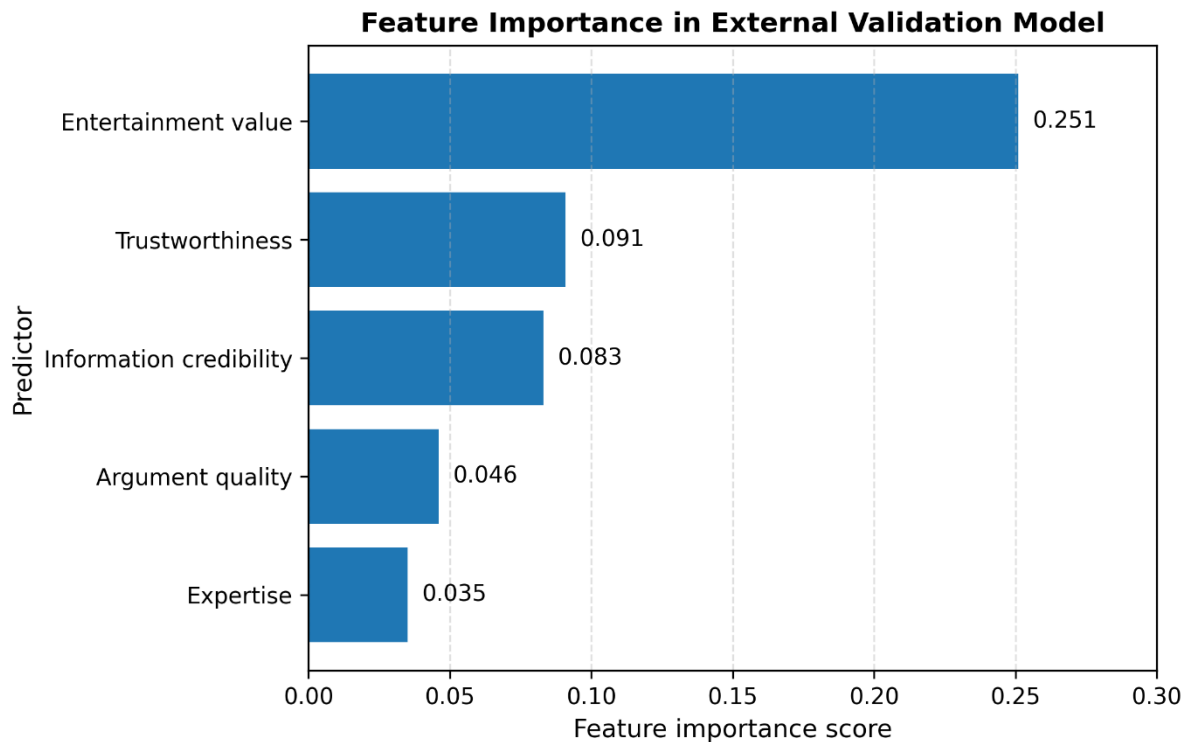


Figure S4. Feature-importance ranking from the best-performing external validation model.

Figure S4 presents the feature-importance ranking from the Gradient Boosting model used in the external robustness validation. Entertainment value showed the highest predictive contribution, followed by trustworthiness, information credibility, argument quality, and expertise.

S3.5 Interpretation of the external validation

The external robustness validation offers additional evidence for the wider predictive importance of influencer credibility and engagement factors related to content. While the R^2 values were modest, the prediction error was acceptable considering the small external sample size and the differing structure of the independent dataset. Therefore, the results should be interpreted with caution. They do not represent a full external SEM replication but support the idea that influencer-driven purchase intention remains linked to credibility, information, and entertainment predictors in an independent survey setting.

Overall, the external validation enhances the study's methodological robustness by showing that the predictive framework extends beyond the initial dataset. The findings also align with the theoretical view that influencer marketing results are influenced not only by source credibility but also by the perceived quality, persuasiveness, and entertainment value of influencer content.

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